PART V · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 4

Progressions everywhere

A **progression** is a trip from chord to chord. A handful of trips turn up in song after song. Learn them by their numbers and you can play them in any key.

THE SECRET
Most songs take the same few trips: home, away, a pull, and home again.

I home · vi iii home's cousins · IV ii away · V the pull back home

The pop four
countless pop songs and ballads

I C → V G → vi Am → IV F

The fifties
old rock 'n' roll and doo-wop

I C → vi Am → IV F → V G

The jazz three-step
jazz standards (as ii7, V7, Imaj7)

ii Dm → V G → I C

The canon
Pachelbel's Canon and its many children

I C → V G → vi Am → iii Em → IV F → I C → IV F → V G

1. Learn the trip by **numbers**: I V vi IV.
2. Pick a key and turn the numbers into chords: in C, **C G Am F**.
3. Play it round and round. Change key: the numbers stay the same.

Same trip, any key

The pop four	I	V	vi	IV
in C	C	G	Am	F
in G	G	D	Em	C
in F	F	C	Dm	B♭
in D	D	A	Bm	G

The twelve-bar blues

I C	I C	I C	I C
IV F	IV F	I C	I C
V G	IV F	I C	V G

The most famous trip of all is twelve bars long and uses only **I, IV and V**. Almost every blues, and a lot of rock 'n' roll, follows it. Play it in C with one chord per bar, four beats each.

Make it bluesy: turn every chord into a seventh (C7, F7, G7, p. 101).

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EXAMPLE

Play the pop four in A major

I ? → V ? → vi ? → IV ?

1. **Write the A major scale** (three sharps) and number the notes.
2. **Find notes 1, 5, 6 and 4.**
3. **Build each cake:** which one is minor?

A, E, F♯m, D: **the pop four in A.** Same trip, new key.

GAME

Name the trip

1 C · Am · F · G

2 Dm · G · C

3 C · G · Am · F

All in C major. Turn each into numbers, then name the trip: the pop four, the fifties or the jazz three-step.

Answer: 1 the fifties (I vi IV V) · 2 the jazz three-step (ii V I) · 3 the pop four (I V vi IV).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

I C → V G → vi Am → IV F

Play C, G, Am, F, four beats each.

Go round four times without stopping, left hand plays the chord's name note (C for C, A for Am), right hand the whole cake. Hum any tune you like over it.

TRAP

× Mixing up the pop four and the fifties: same four chords, different order. Listen to which chord comes second.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 95 · Cadences p. 118 · Chords under a melody p. 121

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 12 · Online: Library › Chords